

Eastern Orthodox distinctives, compared to “Western Christianity”

A Pastoral Letter. Clean Friday, Great Lent, 2025-02-07

VIDEO: <https://youtu.be/eGoye2QWRmo>

HTML: <https://www.orthodox.net/post.html?eastern-orthodox-distinctives-compared-to-western-christianity&id=67cb52f81c12c4000102d0a4>
http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechesis_2025-03-07+eastern-orthodoxy-compared-to-western-christianity.docx
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May God bless you and enlighten you during this Great Lent. I hope you absorb some of what I have said about Great Lent, that it is not only a time for asceticism, which is actually secondary to its purpose. It is a time to try to open up our hearts just a little bit and have a little bit more compunction, and the light of God will come into our dark hearts and illuminate them. To the extent that we open up our hearts, God will come into our hearts.

Many people are preparing for baptism on Holy Saturday, and some may be baptized later in the year or the next Pascha. You should use whatever time you have before baptism to learn the Orthodox Christian lifestyle. Actually, everyone should use whatever time they have left in their short life to learn the Orthodox Christian lifestyle.

Perhaps it's ironic to use the word “lifestyle” because it is usually used in the context of some frivolous things that people do, such as the influencers of our time who live in a frivolous and useless way that seems to be very exciting to many people.

It is very important for you to develop an Orthodox Christian way of looking at things, that is, to see everything in a spiritual way. Nobody taught me anything about that until I became an Orthodox Christian.

I was thinking about the differences between a so-called “Protestant” and a pious Orthodox Christian. If we look at the difference between a “Protestant” and an Orthodox Christian, both of whom are not very serious, then there's not really much difference. But if you took the cream of the crop of each belief system, I think there are some substantial differences and there may be many things that you need to unlearn.

It's strange to refer to “Protestants,” because nobody is really protesting anymore, at least not against an institutional church, and the term is not “inclusive” enough. So, using a word that is popular in our time but not according to the spirit of our time, I would like to say that “including” any Christian beliefs that are not Orthodox as “Western” might be a better way of identifying differences. Of course, there's the Western Orthodox Rite, and those who practice that rite with zeal, sobriety, and piety are not “Western” in their thinking. They are Eastern. Unfortunately, the West has been spiritually dead for a very long time since before the Enlightenment, which is probably the most ironic term for a historical movement of all time.

Western “Christianity” has certain distinctives that are substantially different than Orthodox Christianity, whether a “Western Christian” is Baptist, Methodist, Roman Catholic, or anything else. I would also include the person who really wasn't raised religiously but believed in the “good book.”

One distinctive is that among the non-Orthodox or the barely Orthodox is a certain low expectation regarding church attendance. For many, this is only mass or service on Sunday morning. Perhaps a really pious Western Christian would go to service on Wednesday evening or Sunday evening, but for the most part, people are accustomed to starvation rations regarding worship. They certainly don't have long preparatory periods before feasts and long periods after feasts, and distinctive fasting periods throughout the year.

This is not the way pious Orthodox Christians live. We want to go to every service that we can because there is great grace when we are praying together. Also, the prayers that we say in public are so incredibly profound and theologically textured and compunctionate, that we cannot duplicate them in our own personal prayer.

As we were serving on Wednesday night, Great Compline with the Great Canon of St. Andrew of Crete, I looked around and saw many people, but still only about 25% of our attendance on Sunday. Of course, during the week, people have all kinds of obligations, and some drive a long distance and have various difficulties with church attendance during the week. I understand that, and am not calling anybody out. Everybody must live their lives according to their conscience, and you will do this well, if you recognize that you have many passions and they are telling you to do the wrong thing, or emphasizing the less important things. We are not Western Christians. All of our services are important, and especially inquirers and catechumens should try to come to everything possible.

Why would I tell you this? Some people don't listen to the priest because they think that's just what he is required to say and "they all talk like that." I hope you don't tune me out about these things. I need the services. I need every single one. You need them too. An Orthodox Christian recognizes the grace present in coming to the services that he longs for them. The "Western Christian" doesn't even have multiple services on his radar. His church bulletin lists Sunday liturgy or Sunday service as the only possibility.

Another distinctive difference between these two types of Christians is that an Orthodox Christian orders his entire life by the church calendar. We are aware of the days and seasons. We prepare for Pascha by a long fast, and with many special prayers and services that are only prayed during this time. Then we have a long holy week where we become very intense in the anticipation of Pascha. Our entire lives are focused around these things. We make sure we have time off of work for Annunciation, which may be during the week, and time off during Holy Week, and certainly for Holy Friday. When I was a Western Christian, I was barely aware of the calendar except for Easter coming up (and this awareness did not alter my lifestyle in any way), and, of course, the Christmas season which, included no fasting, but lots of going to Christmas parties and a nebulous kind of "Christmas spirit".

Another distinctive is that Orthodox Christians prepare for the Sunday service with prayers before the service. I never remember any of those things as a Western Christian. We got up in the morning, and when I was Roman Catholic, we did not eat, and when I was Protestant I might have eggs and bacon, and then we went to service. An Orthodox Christian would prepare for Sunday service by going to the vigil, or at least Vespers, and saying the prayers of preparation

for holy Communion before coming on Sunday morning to receive the holy Eucharist in the liturgy.

I think this is because a huge Orthodox distinctive regarding the Divine liturgy, or what some people might call Mass or what some people might call “service”, is that we are going to Divine liturgy in order to meet God and partake in the body and blood of Jesus Christ, and be changed. It makes sense to prepare for that.

Another distinctive is that we have prayers in the prayer book, and we use them. And we love the Psalter. And we love prostrations, and we do them. It is fine to pray in our own words a little bit here and there, but if that’s all you’re doing, you are missing out. There is a certain prejudice against prayers in the book. When I was a college student, the idea was that praying prayers in the book was “religion,” and not having a personal relationship with God. Actually, nothing is further from the truth. We have a relationship with God when we learn how to talk to

God. And we have a relationship with God when we learn compunction. And we have a relationship with God when we learn the truth about God. All of these distinctives are present in our prayers in books.

Another distinctive is that we emphasize the saints, not as some sort of magic intercessors for us but as examples of those who fought the good fight and finished the course. If you have not started reading lives of the saints, you should. Of course ,the saints are intercessors for us, and equally so, they are examples for us. They have trodden the path that we are trying to traverse. Their inspirations for us, and mentors, and guides.

Those are a few things I thought about this week. I hope they edify you in some way.

May God bless you and help you in all things.

Unworthy Priest Seraphim Holland